

CONTESTING THE WORLD AND THE DIVINE: BALTHASAR'S TRINITARIAN "RESPONSE" TO GIANNI VATTIMO'S SECULAR CHRISTIANITY

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Introduction

The contemporary contestation between partisans of secularism and partisans for a resurgence of traditional religious forms is a contest for meaning, a contest over the causes of violence, and a contest to define the human good. Indeed, because so many of the claims involved in this struggle point to ideas as causes or at least facilitators of human evil and suffering, apologetic genealogies and typologies proliferate from both sides to locate, circumscribe, and evaluate one's adversary.¹ Contemplated within a theological orbit, this struggle is a hermeneutic one, that is, a struggle over the proper interpretation of the God-world relation.

The Italian late-modern Catholic philosopher and former member of the European Parliament, Gianni Vattimo, and the Swiss Catholic theologian, Hans Urs von Balthasar, provide two radically divergent perspectives on secularism and Christian faith. For all their differences, however, they vie for space in an intellectual landscape populated by many of the same thinkers and catalyzed by the same shift from modernity to postmodernity. Vattimo and Balthasar both find in Martin Heidegger, for instance, a crucial thinker who helps reestablish the importance of contemplation, calls into question a culture all too preoccupied with calculation and domination, and speaks to the loss of wonder in the face of Being that resists the ontotheological error of making Being into a being, a thing for mere manipulation. Heidegger's view

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of truth as *aletheia* or disclosure, his stress on “attunement” to Being, and even his valorization of event all find their place in the work of the two authors to be discussed. In addition to Heidegger, the Trinitarian epochalism of Joachim di Fiore and the philosophical theology of G. W. F. Hegel figure prominently in their works, albeit with markedly different evaluative assessments.

Beyond such philosophical affinities, Vattimo and Balthasar also find areas of theological accord. They each decline to limit the effects of God’s *kenosis* in Christ to the Church, and see in this divine act an event that has a ripple effect in Western cultural history, an effect on the very meaning of Being, and an effect on God. Undoubtedly, they also agree that the kenotic descent of the Son is directly related to the development and content of secularism. In addition, their shared emphasis on divine *kenosis* ushers in a shared emphasis on the Trinity as the Christian symbol that directs and conditions all meaning. Such shared philosophical and theological space provides a preliminary justification for considering these two otherwise opposed thinkers together. Our present cultural moment provides a second justification.

If it is true that the issues of secularism and religion’s return provoke passionately opposed positions, then a discussion of two very different responses to these issues promises to shed light on our interpretive options. Vattimo’s position will appear attractive to Christian readers in a post-Enlightenment age predominantly for its opposition to metaphysical violence, its support of human autonomy and becoming, and its attempt to interpret the modern age in terms of Christian love and tolerance. One suspects it is Vattimo’s concern for peace that leads him to pay homage to Enlightenment fears of religious fanaticism, but also chasten Enlightenment and post-Enlightenment hubris by way of reflection on the meaning of hermeneutics itself. In this philosophical and theological horizon, Vattimo argues, faith and reason must get beyond any naïve positivism and recognize their shared terrain. Vattimo’s assessment of the current cultural moment then leads him to advocate an attenuated religiosity. Vattimo advocates a form of unlimited apophaticism or nihilism where all ideas and ideological structures suffer dissolution under the intrepid weakening of Being, where Being as foundation or essence comes to be reinterpreted as event or announcement. He then graphs onto the history of Being (*Seinsgeschichte*) a specifically theological reading of this history, drawing on the epochal and progressivist Trinitarianism of Joachim di Fiore (1135–1201). Included in Vattimo’s discussion is an endorsement of Martin Heidegger’s reading of Western intellectual history combined with a remarkably sanguine assessment of secularism. Indeed, his “ontological weakening” thesis combines with a kenotic Christology to yield a view that the secular is a suitable inscription of Christianity sadly misunderstood by those committed to outdated foundationalisms. For Vattimo, the secular should be proclaimed and celebrated as a new event of Being.

Vattimo's views will find a hearing for any number of reasons, some of which may be superficial, while others shed light on issues that Christian theology must address. On the superficial side of things, Vattimo's work seems to sum up and justify present cultural predilections for whatever is new in opposition to the past, and for whatever is "spiritual" in some vague sense over against whatever is "institutional" in another but equally vague sense. More significantly, Vattimo suggests that the turn to philosophical hermeneutics may not be as trouble-free for theology as is sometimes supposed. His own reading of philosophical history indicates that hermeneutics is an event that presupposes the end of metaphysics not only historically, but theoretically as well. Any theology, including that of Balthasar, that sees in metaphysics the possibility of a non-coercive mediating discourse for revelation will find in Vattimo a rather serious obstacle. An equally important issue raised by Vattimo, and an issue unavoidable for theology, is the relation between Christianity, secularism, and how the Christian theologian who stands on hermeneutic ground ought to interpret the latter in view of the center of her faith. If theologians such as Barth, Balthasar, and de Lubac, among others, truly seek to interpret existence on the basis of Christian faith, then existence in a secular age must also receive a theological interpretation in relation to the doctrines of Trinity and Christology. Indeed, Vattimo is right to observe that any simple doctrine of divine alterity will not suffice for Christian theology. Finally, Vattimo offers a vision of a philosophically sophisticated, non-dogmatic Christianity rooted in friendship with God and an ethic of love. Such a vision is bound to have general cultural allure, and in fact may sound rather attractive to theologians as well.

Although we will find that Balthasar contests Vattimo's interpretation of our cultural moment and of Christianity at almost every point, Balthasar does agree with Vattimo that Christianity makes a substantial contribution to a secularized worldview. But unlike Vattimo, Balthasar proclaims a radically transcendent God who is in no way collapsible or reducible to nature, Being, creation, or to any element of human being, including cultural consensus. Balthasar's "No" to what he considers idolatry springs first from his reading of the Old Covenant and continues in a deepened fashion in his reading of the New. The Old Covenant prepares for or educates toward the New by clearing away idols and making space for the incarnation of the divine image that judges all other images and grounds their possibility. Insofar as secular modernity tends toward a Promethean usurpation of the divine—admittedly made plausible through Christ's *kenosis*—Balthasar argues that it must be resisted by a non-Joachimite, that is, non-evolutionary Trinitarian reading of biblical revelation. Promethean modernity is not to be celebrated, but lamented and cast off lest humanity become its own greatest idol. Idolatry critique, however, is not the end of the story that Balthasar wants to tell. In contrast to Vattimo's tightly systematic version of nihilistic Christianity, which would leave Christianity devoid of most of its content, Balthasar calls

for and advances a content-rich Christian theology that nevertheless maintains the apophatic edge of Old Testament idolatry critique. Balthasar wants more: more content and more points of view. But the “more” is precisely what stands to criticize any short changing of biblical revelation on the one hand and human experience on the other.

This essay makes no pretense of offering a neutral genealogy of either Vattimo’s or Balthasar’s views. Instead, I present a sustained, Balthasar-influenced critique of Vattimo’s thought. I will argue in the first half of the essay that Vattimo’s brand of nihilistic Christianity is neither new nor successful. To argue that Vattimo’s form of thought is not new, I will need to show that precursors exist. Gotthold Lessing, G. W. F. Hegel, and Thomas Altizer fill this bill in considerable degree. While lack of originality is not in itself a theological flaw, the problem for Vattimo is that he never realizes the theoretical consequences of his particular influences, especially of Hegelian influence. It is Hegel’s thought that proves most disruptive, for if Hegel is his prime influence, then Vattimo’s position against metaphysical grounding or ontotheology becomes highly suspect, indeed impossible to maintain.² Not only does Hegelian influence disrupt Vattimo’s own theoretical goals, but it also undermines any attempt to provide a genuinely Christian theology of secularism. A third aspect of my argument is that Vattimo’s systematic negation of divine transcendence, his self-placement in the Age of Spirit, and his particular advocacy of a spiritual sense reading of Scripture end up in a kind of fatalism and idolatry of present cultural consensus that suffers no critique. System swallows up criticism while it also severely limits both theological content and interpretive options.

While part one is a Balthasar-influenced critique of Vattimo, part two presents three aspects of Balthasar’s constructive theology that directly address significant concerns found in Vattimo’s work. Section One treats Balthasar’s appropriation and critique of Heidegger’s thought within a Christian frame of reference. As evidenced by his ample appropriation of Heideggerian terminology and his substantive agreement with Heidegger’s criticisms of modern thought, Balthasar finds in Heidegger an important figure for his work. Nevertheless, it will be important in this section to shed light on Balthasar’s critique of Heidegger in *Glory of the Lord* 5.³ This critique offers a riposte to Heidegger’s theoretical preeminence within Vattimo’s putatively Christian milieu. Section Two contrasts Balthasar’s hermeneutic of the Old and New Covenants to Vattimo’s Joachimite-inspired view. Balthasar explicitly opposes Joachim’s Trinitarian progressivism due to what he considers its modern history of effects. For Balthasar, Old and New Covenant revelation each offer different forms of apophaticism that never support a system of total negation or dissolution of divine transcendence. It is precisely divine transcendence, Balthasar argues, that removes idols and prepares for the Image present in the New Covenant. Section Three rises from the Image into the Trinitarian relations, where Balthasar finds a properly theological ground

for unity-in-difference, and support for the gratuity of Being, the liveliness of creation and history, and the advent of the new.

A. Pedagogy in Departing: Vattimo's Nihilistic Christianity

Gianni Vattimo's most prominent philosophical guides are Friedrich Nietzsche and Martin Heidegger, who, he believes, each help Western civilization depart from a metaphysical and moralistic world view caught up in violence for a culture open to the events and announcements of Being at every stage of historical existence. Vattimo comes to see Heidegger and Nietzsche as true prophets of secular Christianity, that is, of a version of Christianity responsive to God's kenotic event in Christ, devoid of metaphysical violence, and hospitable to pluralism. Such a theological response to pluralism, however, is more the destination than the departure. We first need to attend to the philosophical departure.⁴

Vattimo endorses Martin Heidegger's reading of the philosophical tradition as a nearly univocal fall from presocratic wonder in the face of Being to a kind of ontological amnesia where the question of Being is forgotten, and reality comes to be conceived as fundamentally manipulable, masterable, and static.⁵ Vattimo's version of nihilism eschews any objective structure of reality found or uncovered behind appearances as a ground, and then used as a criterion to judge contemporary claims and experience. It is precisely this ongoing attenuation and nihilation of absolutes and certainties that Vattimo labels "ontological weakening."⁶

In the wake of such metaphysical conceptions that would support absolute moral and truth claims, Nietzsche and Heidegger are correct, he judges, to refigure truth as announcement, Being as event.⁷ Nietzsche's own ill-received announcement in the marketplace of God's murder, in Vattimo's view, is not directed towards the God of Jesus Christ proclaimed in Scripture, but toward the God of metaphysics who is rightly put to rest.⁸ To Vattimo, metaphysical conceptions of God as ground or cause, as foundation or source, reek of the will to power.⁹ Such conceptions use Being or God to punish those who would oppose the one right theoretically and morally given order. But if objectivity constitutes a dream from which late-modernity must awake, then we must admit that Nietzsche and Heidegger are right: all is interpretation. If all is interpretation, then all of our certainties become contingent and revisable in light of new experience or a new "announcement." In other words, truth and Being will be inherently historicized.

It is with a view to the contingency and revisability of truth claims that Vattimo embraces the hermeneutical turn. On his view, philosophical categories such as "hermeneutics," "narrative," and "ontological weakening" serve to emphasize the contingency and revisability of all claims, thus maintaining not only conceptual modesty, but also faithfulness to a biblical notion of the "contingency and historicity of our existing."¹⁰ Thus claims to knowledge must not be absolute claims, but should take place in a more humble key that

respects the changing events of history. In at least one theological sense, we might note, Vattimo's proposal sounds promising. His philosophical emphasis on event could lead to a valorization of the events of biblical revelation such that greater stress comes to be placed on concrete revelation over and above abstract speculations. Yet this is not the road that Vattimo takes.

Rather, Vattimo begins to forsake theoretical modesty when he makes teleological use of Heidegger: "Hermeneutics, if it wishes to be consistent with its own rejection of metaphysics, cannot but present itself as the most persuasive philosophical interpretation of a situation or 'epoch,' and thereby, necessarily, of a provenance."¹¹ In other words, the hermeneutical turn, which claims that "all is interpretation," indicates that even this claim is an interpretation—an appropriate one to be sure, but an interpretation that can only arise at a particular time in Western history due to Western cultural momentum. As Luca D'Isanto notes, Vattimo's recognition warrants a "narrative, genealogical interpretation of Western modernity."¹²—that is, an account of the meaning of this philosophical journey in terms of the meaning of Being. Vattimo labels this journey the "nihilistic vocation of hermeneutics."¹³ Hermeneutics is fated to arise only after philosophy realizes the dead end of traditional metaphysics. Thus, the hermeneutic turn dovetails with "the history of Being as the story of a 'long goodbye', of an interminable weakening of Being. In this case, the overcoming of Being is understood only as a recollection of the oblivion of Being, never as making Being present again, not even as a term that always lies beyond every formulation."¹⁴ If "right-wing" Heideggerians await the return of Being, Vattimo's "leftist" reading of Heidegger proposes the consistent banishing and vanishing of essence.¹⁵ It is precisely the movement of philosophical reflection itself and upon itself that arrives at this conclusion. In other words, it is philosophical self-consciousness that realizes that the end of metaphysics makes hermeneutics necessary.

According to Vattimo, hermeneutics, when rightly understood, proclaims and perhaps "promotes" this intrepid weakening of structurally strong institutions and metaphysical interpretations of reality; it must get on with its vocation always to interpret under the sign of weakness. In other words, any interpretation will also be subject to the condition of ontological weakening, while "strong" interpretations, by definition, will be unpersuasive because they lapse into metaphysics. Nietzsche and Heidegger teach us not a departure on the way to a destination, but always to be departing. One is always leaving, and never arriving, for arrival signifies an end, a completion, a presence. Heidegger and Nietzsche, according to Vattimo, show us that all metaphysical-moral structures suffer a departure of their essence, a withdrawal and negating of the authority given to those political, social, and doctrinal structures one thinks real. While Vattimo attempts to take this lesson to heart, he nevertheless appears destined to make of a nihilistic hermeneutic a necessary destination.

B. Theological Pedagogy and Apophatic Epochalism

Given Vattimo's predilections for Nietzsche, Heidegger, and a general negation of authority, it may come as a surprise that in *After Christianity* and in *Belief*, Vattimo wants to persuade us that Christianity drives and structures his acceptance of the nihilistic vocation of post-modernity.¹⁶ Vattimo is rightly concerned that whatever the return to religion in Europe means, it should not be a movement towards intolerant, violent, and purely metaphysical religiosity. Still, it is his very questionable view that his weak ontology doctrine can help resist these undesirable developments by offering a nihilistic Christian interpretation of secularism. Indeed, not only is his "weak ontology" "a transcription of the Christian message," but his "preference for the Heideggerian solution to . . . contemporary philosophical problems is conditioned, and profoundly inspired, by the Christian inheritance."¹⁷ More specifically, Christianity teaches that God is not master, but friend.¹⁸

The central effect of this Christian inspiration, Vattimo contends, is the outbreak of secularism or the process of secularization.¹⁹ Vattimo asserts that secularism is suitably figured in terms of Joachim of Fiore's third age and as an extension of Christ's *kenosis*, understood not so much in its traditional and more carnal fashion as the incarnation of a particular individual, but rather after its "spiritual sense" in terms of an ontology of weakening.²⁰ Secularism mediates the philosophy of ontological weakening and the event of God's self-emptying; indeed, secularism ought to be understood as the "very essence of Christianity . . ."²¹ because as a reception of the revelation of divine *kenosis*, it announces the "dissolution of divine transcendence," of the metaphysical God of otherness and violence.²² Secularism is the form that God's *kenosis* takes to express the non-violence and non-otherness of God.

In short, philosophical progress beyond metaphysics yields hermeneutics which, in turn, specifies the character of late modern experience as one of ontological weakening. Secularist, pluralistic signs of the times are then baptized as the most relevant marks of God's ongoing *kenosis*, so that God as moral gatekeeper and as transcendent other dissolves along with ecclesial doctrine,²³ natural law,²⁴ the divine attributes,²⁵ and the literal sense of scripture.²⁶ Within Vattimo's telling of the story, the Philippians hymn to Christ's self-emptying becomes a trope for the intrepid death of God as transcendent other and the irruption of secularism as an ultimate mode of divine *kenosis*. On Vattimo's reading, *kenosis* is understood in literal and univocal terms. Traditional distinctions between immanent and economic Trinity, ontology and epistemology, faith and reason wither away in a late modern context where all is interpretation. It is important to note as well the transformation of theological language from the analogical to univocal plane. Divine emptying is understood literally to negate divine transcendence such that God undergoes a real and total dissolution. Thus, in contrast to the Christian tradition's efforts to hold together transcendence and *kenosis*, for instance in the distinction between Father and Son, in Vattimo's conceptually parsimo-

nious interpretation there is no longer a transcendent God, or no longer a plausible interpretation of God as transcendent.²⁷

Vattimo's erasure of divine transcendence supports a rather severe truncation of the Christian scriptures. Like Lessing before him, who also appeals to Joachim, Vattimo would have us eliminate the Old Covenant because the God of the Old Covenant is transcendent and therefore does not fit into the process of secularization: "the God who at the end of the secularization process is recovered as wholly other is the God of the Old Testament (let me say this without any anti-Semitic implication) and not the God incarnate in Jesus Christ, of the New Testament revelation, and even less the God understood as spirit in the third age prophesied by Joachim of Fiore."²⁸ We can add to this Vattimo's association in *Belief* of Catholic regression to metaphysics and literalism with Old Testament faith and his lamentation of the "predominance of Judaic religiosity in the return of religion into contemporary thought (let me make clear that this observation has no anti-Semitic intention whatsoever)."²⁹ Of course, in a world of hermeneutics, authorial intention, and thus the parenthetical statements above, carries little clout. The tradition upon which Vattimo draws, here as elsewhere, belongs to G. E. Lessing and G. W. F. Hegel, each of whom trade on Joachim's Trinitarian progressivism, each of whom put the Old Covenant behind as definitively past, and, finally, each of whom espouse theologies at best unfriendly to Judaism.³⁰ Indeed, whatever Vattimo's stated intentions, it is difficult to see how the recommendation to eliminate Torah and the God revealed there might be seen positively by Jews.

C. Strategies of Delegitimation and Legitimation

A key issue lies in Vattimo's justification for his hermeneutic practice. Vattimo's hermeneutic involves what we might call strategies for delegitimation and legitimation. One such strategy is to radically historicize scriptural revelation. By "historicize" I mean that for Vattimo, much of Scripture, though perhaps useful at other times for other people, now suffers from the ongoing development of the historical process. Much of scripture is simply passé and out of step with the cultural moment or "signs of the times." The result is to eliminate the authority of scripture's literal sense and to severely upset canonical integrity. Of course, this move proves somewhat awkward for Vattimo, given that his philosophical position serves to dissolve the authority of Scripture, even as he would extol the God of Scripture over against the God of philosophy and metaphysics. While this appears contradictory, Vattimo might respond that in fact he is simply carrying through the implications of divine *kenosis*, proclaimed in Philippians 2:5–11, and not imposing an external philosophical criterion on the Bible. One would expect, however, that if Vattimo recommends the God of Scripture, he would have to offer an interpretation of actual biblical passages, including Old Testament texts. But as it stands, what Vattimo means when he speaks of the God of the Bible

reduces to this pericope in Paul's letter—and even that passage is cut short prior to Jesus' exaltation to the right hand of the Father—and a passage from John. The God of the Bible turns out to be the God of approximately eight verses—and, one might add, verses read with an extreme literalism, and apart from any traditional Trinitarian theology.

A closely related strategy of delegitimation derives from Vattimo's use of Joachim's Trinitarian progressivism. It becomes evident that Vattimo's self-proclaimed existence in Joachim's third age or "age of spirit" is what allows him to see contemporary progress beyond more primitive stages of religiosity, and beyond the literal sense of scripture.³¹ Ontological weakening joins with Joachimite epochalism to delegitimize much of the scriptural witness. The secular or kenotic divine is, as he clearly states, not the God of the Old Covenant, but the God of the Age of Spirit. But this means that for Vattimo it is the present cultural moment, both philosophically in terms of hermeneutics' nihilistic vocation, and sociologically in terms of Western pluralism, that becomes the new authority for interpretation. Contrary to his assertions, it is not the incarnation of Jesus as we receive it in the New Testament and in tradition that forms Vattimo's hermeneutic key, but rather his philosophical commitments that thoroughly determine his reading of Christianity. What is important to notice is that given Vattimo's system, there really is no way to contest a scriptural reading from scripture itself, for Vattimo's appeal is not to the text, whether literalistic, traditional, spiritual, or otherwise, but to an account of the history of Being which then functions to give the authoritative and necessary "interpretation" of the text. Of course, it is appropriate to expect that even a "spiritual sense" interpretation is an interpretation of something, that it can be grounded in the text itself, especially given that the God of the Bible has been invoked. Instead, Vattimo promotes contemplation without an object to contemplate; scripture thus loses any capacity to challenge the biases and predilections of its interpreter. Vattimo's rather rigid system of negation becomes an all-encompassing interpretation that systematically eliminates plurality because it eliminates anything that his philosophical conclusions do not already stamp with approval.

Vattimo's modes of delegitimation, we should observe, function simultaneously as modes of legitimation. It is nihilism's vocation that reduces entities or strong interpretations and weakens them, thus opening the way for a secular, pluralistic age that is nevertheless religious in some general sense. The same epochal metanarrative that delegitimizes older forms of religiosity proclaims *au courant* secularism and pluralism as contemporary modes of divine *kenosis*, at least under the guise of a "spiritual sense" or "free" reading of scripture. Given the current moment as a profound event of Being, Vattimo suggests that this same cultural moment calls not for action and concerns for justice, but rather moves beyond the epoch of action to one of contemplation,³² a reading that has its philosophical corollary in Vattimo's twist on Marx's eleventh thesis on Feuerbach: "until now philosophers have seen fit to

describe the world, now the moment has arrived to interpret it."³³ Of course, Vattimo's rhetorical twist on Marx seeks to distinguish between a metaphysical view of the world, such that the real is that which stands beneath appearances waiting to be dis-covered, and a thoroughgoing hermeneutic view that denies this metaphysical sub-structure, and sees all reality as involved in the free play or contest of interpretations. Given, however, that the passage from Marx that he alters is a passage calling for action—and, moreover, action on behalf of the poor and downtrodden in particular—Vattimo's particular interpretation of the third epoch would seem to suggest that secularism ushers in a time beyond such need. It seems that as Marx attempted to overturn Hegelian idealism through a concern for human, material well-being, Vattimo is content to reverse the process and place the system back on its head. This, of course, is a troubling position at best. More than Marx, it recalls a line of Alexander Pope's contribution to theodicy, *Essay on Man*: "whatever is, is right."³⁴ What thus gets legitimated—and legitimated as a kind of arrival—would appear to be the secular age exactly as it currently is.

There is, of course, a clear reason for Vattimo to distance himself from the prophetic voice of Marx, especially given the destruction and consequent anxiety associated with utopian secular movements in Europe in the twentieth century. While Vattimo lauds Novalis, for instance, he distances himself from Novalis' prophetic tone in his "Christendom or Europe"³⁵ essay, and from the more nefarious effects of Hegelian-influenced thought in Germany.³⁶ Vattimo's utopia is not a political utopia, but an aesthetic one, a utopia wherein as many as possible would be able to contemplate and enjoy the many goods in life.³⁷ Nevertheless, Vattimo is once again not nearly suspicious enough of Hegelian influence. First, for Vattimo, the beyond, that is, the afterlife as hope, plays no role whatsoever in one's existence here and now. For instance, he is uninterested in the forming of communities of witness to this eschatological promise rooted in the kingdom of God and grounded in the Spirit. To do this, of course, would then suggest a tension, found most obviously in John's gospel, between the Church and the world, between Jesus' vision of the kingdom and earthly kingdoms. Hope stands unrelated to faith in Vattimo's thought. On this point, Vattimo essentially follows Hegel, in contrast to Joachim, even if he wants to hold out some possibility that there is something like a resurrection. Second, Vattimo's Hegelian dissolution of divine transcendence profoundly compromises Christian hope for anything like eternal life. Christian hope for eternal life is based upon the Christian belief that the Creator ultimately holds sovereignty over the vicissitudes of history, and can thus re-create what is his creation in the first place. For the New Testament, hope is rooted in the faith that Jesus is risen, in turn a trust grounded in divine power. Hope for the dead and consolation for the bereaved cannot be grounded in a "weak god." Third, Vattimo's attempt to alter Hegel by switching from political formation to aesthetic contemplation really does not help his case. For in fact, to expand

the numbers of people for whom aesthetic enjoyment is possible is, I would imagine, to expand the numbers of people who are living above a subsistence level existence; and to do this suggests that political and economic action cannot be forsworn, indeed, that action for justice and contemplation should not be opposed to one another, lest the former become mindless, ugly, and violent, and the latter a mere consumerist accumulation of pretty things. This is what Marx intuited rightly, namely, that the Hegelian enterprise forestalled precisely the prophetic element of Christian and Jewish existence, and substituted for it a contemplation that only ever looked backward, a contemplation that gave into that to which Heidegger too would have us yield: to the *moira* that is the fate and destiny, the sway, of impersonal Being.³⁸

D. Apophasis and Pedigree

If Hegel does exercise a strong pull on Vattimo's position,³⁹ we should immediately wonder whether anything like an apophatic position can hold, given that Hegel consistently and vehemently rejects apophaticism.⁴⁰ First, however, we have to be clear as to what we mean by "apophatic" in Vattimo's work. To use this term here indicates that no knowledge of a reality behind appearances is available to us. There are no essences, no natures we can conceptually grasp, and no absolute doctrinal and ethical pronouncements we can make. For Vattimo, apophaticism and nihilism join to erase the very place from which transcendent values and meanings, origins and goals might arise. This is what is meant by "all is interpretation" and what Nietzsche means when he notes that if this is the case, then we must become gods, that is, providers of a horizon of meaning, purpose, direction, light, and warmth, all the things that vanish when a civilization sharpens its knives against God. One question, then, becomes whether Vattimo is able to maintain his apophatic nihilism, or if, in fact, he has simply switched one claim to know truth for another. I plan to address this question indirectly, by examining the pedigree of Vattimo's ideas and discerning just how strong the Hegelian influence is. We will move backwards from Death of God theology to its nineteenth-century precursor, and also include a brief mention of Gotthold Lessing.

In *After Christianity*, Vattimo acknowledges his debt to the Death of God theology, though he believes this theology will tend to join secularism to a God who is transcendent other. Having in mind Bonhoeffer, Vattimo guesses that other Death of God theologians follow suit and fail to articulate "an explicit theory of secularization and of the death of God as the positive affirmation of divinity based on the idea of incarnation . . . contemporary thought emphasizes the disappearance of the sacred from the world precisely by affirming transcendence as the total 'alterity' of the biblical God."⁴¹ Oddly, Vattimo places Thomas Altizer in this group.⁴² In fact, however, it is Altizer's *Gospel of Christian Atheism* that Vattimo reprises nearly step by step, influence by influence, and there can be little doubt that Altizer did articulate an

explicit theory of secularization rooted in the ideas of *kenosis*, incarnation, and divine death. The following passage comes from Altizer, but could just as easily be written by Vattimo: "the radical Christian seeks a total union with Jesus or the Word, and repudiates the God who is the sovereign Creator and the transcendent Lord."⁴³ Like Vattimo, Altizer is interested in neither Jesus of Nazareth nor in the Jesus of Church tradition, but in the incarnate Word as he will come to be known in the third epoch or Joachim's Age of Spirit.⁴⁴ For the "radical Christian," Altizer contends, "there is no way to true faith apart from an abolition or dissolution of God himself", thus making it at least thinkable "that even Nietzsche was a radical Christian."⁴⁵ Of course Altizer's path requires the rejection of a closed canon⁴⁶ and the interpretation of New Testament resurrection texts away from the resurrection of one individual and to the presence of the divine to or as the secular age of a new humanity.⁴⁷ Like Vattimo, Altizer eliminates from Paul's narrative of *kenosis* the exaltation of Jesus to the right hand of the Father, for such an exaltation would reinstate the "primordial Creator, an eternal and unchanging Lord."⁴⁸ Thus reading the Pauline *kenosis* trope through Hegelian eyes, divine self-emptying in the historical person of Jesus becomes a wholesale "self-negation" no longer confined to a particular historical moment: "To know that God is Jesus is to know that God himself has become flesh: no longer does God exist as transcendent Spirit or sovereign Lord, now God is love."⁴⁹ As for Vattimo and for Hegel, love appears for Altizer to have the quality of an identity between the divine and the secular that has overcome alienation, an alienation which includes the Old Testament picture of God's relation to the world and many aspects of the New Testament. In this sense, difference, whether between the divine and the world or within the divine construed as Trinity, gets eliminated or dissolved, and with it goes the ground for a world that is genuinely other than the divine and rooted in God's gracious Being. For Altizer, Hegel, and Vattimo, if God is to be love, then God can no longer be essentially different from the world itself.⁵⁰ Such difference, for Vattimo, bespeaks an outdated metaphysical and violent deity. Thus, secularism is necessary given the definition of God as love or as friend, both of which, when univocally construed, exclude the possibility of God as Lord. Altizer sees his reading as a Hegelian reading of the incarnation, one that abandons the God of creation and the Old Covenant, even the God of the New Covenant, for the idea of incarnation rooted in the symbol of divine *kenosis* available to those who stand in the awareness of the third epoch. It should be rather clear that Vattimo's speculative theology is not new. The strong pneumatological turn and the Trinitarian progressivism that springs from Joachim serves for Altizer and for Vattimo as a way to give theological movements a kind of contemporary authority over against the biblical canon, Church authorities, tradition, etc.

While Vattimo does not see Altizer as a precursor, he does name Lessing and Hegel as theological and philosophical trailblazers. Lessing takes up

Joachim's visionary theology in his essay, "The Education of the Human Race," and there argues that revelation in its sensible, pictorial form,⁵¹ that is, part of what Hegel will term "positivity,"⁵² serves as a vehicle for rational truth. Once rational truth is understood rationally or in its inner meaning, the vehicle may be discarded. The effect is to leave behind the Old Testament, greatly reduce the substance of Christian faith, scriptures, and doctrine, and to dissolve divine transcendence in the age of the Spirit, offering reincarnation as an alternative to resurrection.⁵³ Vattimo's thought reprises more nearly Lessing's Joachim than it does the twelfth-century Benedictine. For Vattimo, the third epoch emerges as philosophy's destiny, a destiny we can record in the movement of reason itself from an onto-theo-logical metaphysics that determines Western cultural and philosophical formation, to the end of metaphysics and onset of hermeneutics, to a stage where the onset of hermeneutics necessarily ushers in the announcement of the intrepid weakening of Being.⁵⁴ To reject the hermeneutic move in its sense as ontological weakening is to fall afoul of the movement of reason and into superstition, perhaps violence. Vattimo's third epoch is a grounded epoch, an inescapable "event" of destiny whose authority springs from the third epoch location of the writer himself. True, philosophical reason has been humbled through Heideggerian analysis, but reason returns with a vengeance as negation, as that which marginalizes all doctrines that do not subscribe to the ontological weakening metaphysic, the *sola interpretazione* of Nietzsche. It seems that even the counter-force of Heidegger cannot hold back the pull of Hegelian metanarrative and ontotheological metaphysics.⁵⁵

A second reason to point out the relation between Vattimo and 1960s Death of God theology, specifically that of Altizer, is to strengthen my suggestion that Hegelian metaphysics are what truly controls the form of Vattimo's thought. Altizer, of course, is under no illusions. He names and appropriates Hegelian influence. Vattimo is less sure. He certainly names Hegel as one of many influences, but never seems to comprehend the full-on invasion of his thought, despite Heideggerian disavowals. I have already suggested various places at which Vattimo clearly follows Hegel, and noted that Altizer, whose work Vattimo reprises at nearly every step, claims Hegel as one of his two primary influences for "radical Christianity." We can now observe, albeit briefly and schematically, Hegelian influence on Vattimo in seven specific points, but first it is important to note the reason for this seven point observation. The issue, here, is not merely one of genealogy or influence. What I want to emphasize is that to the extent that Vattimo's system is Hegelian, it loses its claim on anything like apophaticism or idolatry critique. In fact, it reifies the given secularism or vision of secularism as revelation of the divine, even if it is a divine active in negation. To be Hegelian is to know quite precisely the nature of the divine. Perhaps more importantly, to the extent that his system is Hegelian, Vattimo's philosophical theology falls well short of the criterion he sets for any theology: it falls short of Love. The seven points

are: (1) the Trinity is de-personalized; (2) the divine-world relation is given a modalistic and ultimately monistic reading; (3) Passibility is radical and history becomes constitutive, or stronger, determinative, of divine being; (4) Scriptural revelation is overcome by a "spiritual sense" reading that envisions a reconciliation between divine being and the being of the world, thus asserting some form of identity; (5) Jesus' historical existence becomes religiously insignificant; (6) Resurrection does not lead to exaltation and end *kenosis*, and does not apply to Jesus as an individual, but rather continues *kenosis* as a general diffusion of divine Being into the secular or as the secular; (7) Divine will, election, missions are excised from theological reflection. We can now discuss these seven points briefly.

What we are calling the "de-personalization" of the Trinity in Vattimo's thought relates directly to the modalistic form of his system. For Vattimo, mutability and events of epochal significance, such as the advent of technoscience and secularism, define the very constitution of divinity as it becomes other than it was. Thus, the Age of the Son means there is no longer a divine as Father, and likewise the transition from Son to Spirit. Classical theology labels this sort of interpretation modalistic in the sense that the eternal, personal distinctions are not considered real, but only ways in which the divine nature shows itself to us. Thus difference, or even differentiating, has no ground in reality. For Vattimo, the eternal personal distinctions of the Godhead dissolve along with divine transcendence as the divine becomes spirit, and spirit takes a kind of form that negates form, what Vattimo calls nihilism. Of course such a position commits itself to the divine as mutable and even determined by a particular epochal interpretation. Vattimo might reject this analysis, and respond that he, like Hegel, is only interpreting what has already occurred. Nevertheless, this response cannot restore any sense of divine freedom, since Vattimo's philosophical commitments, and his interpretation of the third and last epoch, each rule out a return to God as Lord or as transcendent Father. We should notice, then, that if Vattimo wants to maintain a traditional Christian hope for eternal life with God, that is, for the resurrection of concrete human beings, he has nonetheless removed the ground for such hope, namely, a Lord who is powerful, beneficent, and free from the vicissitudes of human history. A deity no longer distinguishable from the nihilating movement of Being offers little solace for the suffering and the dead. Hegel is more straightforward. He argues that reconciliation, to be complete, conceptually must include a reconciliation of the here and the beyond. Any maintenance of a "beyond" keeps religious thought at a pictorial or positivistic level that also represents a form of alienation to be overcome or reconciled.

Once Vattimo accepts the mutability and passibility of the divine, together with a form of Hegelian modalism and an inner worldly utopian vision, he is unable to give account for Christian hope (1 Peter 3:15). The Hegelian view of divine death and resurrection only compounds the difficulties. Vattimo

follows Hegel in extending *kenosis* back to creation,⁵⁶ and given that the Old Covenant and transcendent Lord are consistently read as oppressive, Vattimo would appear to share Hegel's rather negative view of creation, or at least of the human relation to the creator as alienation that must be overcome in the Age of Spirit. We can notice here a crucial rhetorical and theological difference between Joachim and Vattimo. For Joachim, the creator God of the Old Testament is fundamentally good as a pedagogue,⁵⁷ whereas for Vattimo the transcendent deity of the Old Testament and of metaphysics is a God of violence. In other words, a deity envisioned as transcendent is for Vattimo a sign of human alienation. By its very nature, the divine as transcendent is negative. At the other end of the biblical narrative, resurrection functions not to verify the goodness of the Creator and not as an offer of hope, but as the convergence of the divine and human in a secularism baptizable as the irruption of the "weak god." Finally, as for Hegel, so for Vattimo the historical life of Jesus is religiously insignificant⁵⁸; only the resurrected Christ, that is, only the spirit as it dissolves divine transcendence into secular society matters; only God's death matters theologically, for it is that death that dissolves divine transcendence and saves us, not from sin, but from the *causa sui*.

If I am correct to tie Vattimo's position to Hegel's, then Vattimo cannot maintain any real apophaticism or nihilistic vocation. He knows far too much. Vattimo stands in the third epoch, from where he determines the very nature of God as intrepid dissolver of form, essence, nature, authority, transcendence, otherness, and, consequently, difference. If interpretation is truly all there is, then, in a sense, Vattimo knows God univocally and perfectly. Indeed, in a real sense, Vattimo creates and "promotes" a very unbiblical understanding of God.

II. Balthasar's theological hermeneutics of the secular

A. Reading Heidegger: Balthasar and the Ontological Difference

The first part of Balthasar's fifteen volume trilogy is a seven volume theological aesthetics designed to restore Beauty to its rightful place at the forefront of the transcendentals of Goodness, Truth, and Being. Apart from beauty, he argues, the world becomes a mass of oppressive, heteronomous commands and "clattering," unpersuasive syllogisms.⁵⁹ Truth and goodness require beauty if they are to compel and impel from within, and not rely on mere authority, or worse, state police. Like Vattimo, Balthasar finds in Heidegger a fellow advocate for the aesthetic, especially apparent in Heidegger's emphasis on thinking as contemplation, his emphasis on the ontological difference, and his view of Being as event. Balthasar, however, maintains a critical distance from Heideggerian ontology, even as he appropriates some of its more profound ideas, and even as Balthasar's theological hermeneutic seeks to buttress Heidegger's own best philosophical impulses. While what follows will note Balthasar's considerable debts to Heidegger, my main point

will be that Balthasar's criticisms of Heidegger apply even more emphatically to Vattimo than to Heidegger himself. Indeed, it may be a surprising claim, but there is a sense in which Balthasar is more nearly Heideggerian than Vattimo, especially once we have realized that Vattimo has permitted Hegel rather than Heidegger to be his director of operations. We will begin with a discussion of this point. A second aspect of our discussion in this section addresses Balthasar's critique of Heidegger's depiction of the ontological difference such that Heidegger's thought moves in the direction of an identity philosophy despite his most ardent wishes. The third aspect of our discussion relates to Balthasar's contention that Heidegger's thought, and by extension Vattimo's, is unable to subsume the glory of the biblical God. Since for Balthasar points two and three are closely related, they will not be split up in any definitive sense here.

When it comes to Heidegger, Balthasar can be highly complimentary. In volume five of *Glory of the Lord*, he offers the following praise: Heidegger offers the "most fertile one [project] from the point of view of a potential philosophy of glory" in the modern period. "In the face of all unmediated forms of theism," von Balthasar writes, "he keeps the process firmly fixed on the main issue, which is the mystery of the immanent distinction between Being and the existent, with his question ('How does God enter philosophy')." ⁶⁰ Balthasar appropriates not only Heidegger's notion of "attunement," but also his negative assessment of a technological, calculating world that has no room for surprise and revelation, ⁶¹ and that conceives of the human being as the center of all meaning. ⁶² But Balthasar appears to know, in a way that Vattimo does not, that to side with Heidegger is to take sides against Hegel, that is, to resist any progressivist notion of salvation history grounded in the necessity of reason. Indeed, the teleological spin that Vattimo lends to Heidegger's thought appears to undo the very contrast that Heidegger draws between himself and Hegel in his essay, "The Onto-Theo-Logical Constitution of Metaphysics." ⁶³ Heidegger rejects, in this essay, Hegelian teleological epochalism that would make each cultural representation of Being a moment in a process toward the end of absolute self-knowledge or "science," for a more nearly dialogical model of philosophical investigation where the attempt is to encounter a metaphysic in its "originary" power and to bring that power to bear on the present. Different epochs do, Heidegger believes, reveal different encounters with Being, but these different forms of encounter are not ordered in some knowable teleology that would then resolve into a particular concept such as "ontological weakening" or "the secular." In his essay on Parmenides, this anti-Hegelian bent becomes apparent. Heidegger wants to revive the power of Parmenides' thought for us, to give "free speech" to lost voices and to listen to a thinker who is more poet than pre-Socratic philosopher. ⁶⁴ Thus for Heidegger, and against modern and Platonic readings, Parmenides is not first and foremost a cog in a machine that is moving to us, but a powerful and poetic voice that calls us to him.

The importance Heidegger attaches to this dialogical approach is considerable. From at least the 1920s in works such as *Being and Time* and his lectures on Leibniz in *The Metaphysical Foundations of Logic*, Heidegger is trying to prioritize Being over thought understood as syllogistic logic or proposition. He refuses the Hegelian option in part because it makes of the ground of Being a thought which accounts for its own ground, thus replacing the priority of Being and the ontological difference with a form of logic that can include Being within the bounds of explanation, thus squelching wonder and surprise. Within Hegelian ontotheology, his work suggests, dialogue becomes a mono-logic. Indeed, Hegel is for Heidegger the adversary who cannot be permitted to return lest a massive ontotheology come with him.⁶⁵

It is evident that Balthasar, although reading against Heidegger's consignment of the Western theological tradition to the scrap-heap of ontotheology, simultaneously reads the voices of the tradition with Heidegger's concerns in mind. A clear case of this is Balthasar's reading of Anselm's works, not as pre-Scholastic or pre-rationalist with rationalist aims, but as a monastic form of thought thoroughly grounded in dialogue, prayer and contemplation that makes a claim on us.⁶⁶ As for Heidegger, so for Balthasar one form of thought should not be reduced to another. The same concern to hear the voices of thinkers from the past comes into play with Balthasar's inclusion of both Bonaventure and Thomas in his "pantheon" of Christian thinkers in volumes two and four of *Glory of the Lord*. Balthasar refuses to exclude one thinker for the other; instead, they both contribute voices to the symphonic, pluralistic tradition that must discern their value to the present community. It is Vattimo's evolutionary interpretation of tradition, one that would envision each successive moment as rendering the past passé, that would rule out just this plurality in favor of a monotony of the present.⁶⁷ Alternatively, a regressive position, that is, a position that held only past or early voices valuable, would be equally monotonous.

Our second and third points relate to Heidegger's concern for the ontological difference, Balthasar's critique of Heidegger's ontology, and Balthasar's view that a biblical theology of glory cannot be subsumed within this ontology, despite the attempts of Heidegger and Vattimo. On Balthasar's reading, Heidegger seeks not so much to shed light on Christian revelation as to get behind Christianity to "primordial Greekness."⁶⁸ The rationale for Heidegger's desire for this recovery becomes clear in his essays on the "pre-Socratic" thinkers, Heraclitus, Anaximander, Parmenides.⁶⁹ This early Greek thought articulates, he thinks, a kind of disinterested availability to whatever is given or released into Being. Such thought remains open to the question, "why is there something rather than nothing,"⁷⁰ and does not close off the question with an answer, as do the Platonic Forms, Christian theism, and even the God of the Bible. Such answers, Heidegger judges, close off questioning, which he identifies with the vocation of philosophy, and also foreclose on wonder by explaining Being, and thus conceptualizing Being as a controllable object.⁷¹ He

argues that this trend continues and worsens in modern rationalist systems such as that of Leibniz, where all historical contingency is given an ontotheological ground in the divine mind. Contingency, then, is erased in favor of necessity.⁷² In short, Heidegger's attempt to reverse Christianity's assimilation of Greek myth by subsuming Christian "motifs" of grace, fall, and faith into a philosophy of being is a laudable attempt to reinstate wonder, difference and surprise at the center of philosophy. Nevertheless, Balthasar judges that this attempt fails in significant ways, both theologically and philosophically. Balthasar's critique of Heidegger focuses on Heidegger's rendition of the ontological difference and his attempt to swallow theological *doxa* or glory within philosophical wonder. Several elements of Balthasar's critique stand out: Balthasar rejects what he contends is an unjustly univocal reading of the Western philosophical tradition as a fall from pre-Socratic wonder into "techné";⁷³ restricts this genealogy of fall to late medieval and modern metaphysics;⁷⁴ and argues that Heidegger's attempt to digest theological *doxa* or glory within a philosophy of Being not only fails, but has an ontotheological effect of its own that Heidegger himself misses. This last point requires discussion as it bears on our treatment of Vattimo.

Balthasar's argument picks up on a theme found also in John Caputo's *Heidegger and Aquinas*,⁷⁵ namely, Heidegger's elimination of the Thomistic distinction between limitless subsisting Being and limitless non-subsisting Being. The elimination of this distinction, Balthasar argues, leads Heidegger to collapse the difference between Being and the world, where Being needs the world to realize itself in a way that could never be said of the Christian God. Being, for Heidegger, is realized in the event of its lighting up, its illumination, which requires a subjective counterpart—that is, *Dasein*, the being or at least locus of Being's event constituted as *Dasein* by this event. There is no Being as event if there is no *Dasein*; there is no *Dasein* if Being does not happen. It is in the dialogue between the objective and subjective side of the event that it can occur.⁷⁶ But then, Balthasar contends, it is the difference between Being and beings that allows for the world to come about, historically, through human agency. In one sense this means that the place of God is taken by the ontological difference itself; the ontological difference becomes the condition for the possibility of a world coming into being, that is, for Being and beings to cooperate in constructing a world. The implication is that human beings become "co-essential" in creation to such a degree that the Greek, Homeric line of demarcation between the gods and mortals has been crossed⁷⁷; there is now an identity. Neither Greek nor Christian, this move, Balthasar believes, revokes wonder precisely because it destroys the *analogia entis*, the ever greater dissimilarity between creator and creature represented metaphysically through the terms "subsistent" and "non-subsistent" Being. "Accordingly," Balthasar writes, "man cannot perform the classical act of wonder in the face of the miraculous ordering of the world, nor the Christian act of a yet deeper wonder at the incomprehensibility of his own and of all

earthly existence. Now he is himself a co-essential part of the mystery of Being which prevails necessarily as such."⁷⁸

A second problem, Balthasar suggests, is that Heidegger's philosophical wonder restricts itself to Being, to the fact that anything is; but wonder must encounter the other side of the ontological difference, namely, that a particular form exists as itself. Being alone cannot account for essence, form, or specific entities. Thus contemplation of *essentia* leads to the realization of the dependence of Being for its realization on entities; Being too is dependent. Consequently, entities point to a higher reality, an absolute freedom that posits them individually, that is, Absolute or limitless subsistent Being and a vast difference between non-subsistent and subsistent Being.⁷⁹ At this point we move toward a theological form of discourse that Heidegger, despite and even because of his desire to keep the question open, would prohibit. But it is precisely this kind of discourse that shows Heidegger's inability to account for the glory of the Christian God and to protect the ontological difference. We should add here that Vattimo only exacerbates the Heideggerian difficulty and in fact shows himself fundamentally uninterested in the original question, "Why is there something rather than nothing?" For Vattimo, the negation of essence, what Augustine would refer to as the "*privatio boni*," becomes the vocation of hermeneutics. Intrepid annihilation flees from wonder at the emergence of Being and from the beauty of form. But this raises a further question: what precisely is it that one contemplates when all things fall under the sway of ontological weakening? Is it this weakening itself? If so, then the beauty and goodness of form must be lost as well. Consequently, pluralism would seem to fade into a monologue of negation.

In contrast to both Heidegger and Vattimo, Balthasar believes that the way to protect the ontological difference is through a recognition of the covenant relation between a personal God of glory, that is, the God of Old and New Covenants, and the human person as finite creature. The personal character of the Covenant God (as self-subsistent Being) and the personal character of the creature as the recipient of the gift of being allows for an analogy and relation ensconced in ever-greater dissimilarity. It is the non-subsistent gift character of Being itself that maintains the ontological difference within relation. The human person exists only insofar as she has first received the free gift of being. Being, in the terms of Jean-Luc Marion, is given;⁸⁰ it does not give itself and so cannot answer in and of itself why any particular thing exists as itself. If we decide to ask, with Balthasar, whether Heidegger's phenomenology can account for biblical glory, we would have to conclude that it cannot. As Balthasar argues, to account for the glory of the biblical God, Heidegger would need to account for the "sovereign and majestic freedom of the God of gracious covenant and absolute love. But Heidegger wishes to banish all that has to do with the will (which decides, elects, judges) from the realm of being."⁸¹ But in Absolute freedom and election lies precisely the "whylessness" that Heidegger extols, yet forfeits, with his particular ontology.

For Balthasar, the fact of existence that leads Heidegger and others to ask, “why is there something rather than nothing,” points to divine freedom, and thus to the radical gratuitousness or “whylessness” of our own being, that Heidegger’s thought, despite his best intentions, fails to acknowledge. As a result, an identity ensues between Being and human being at each side of the ontological difference, the difference itself becoming a kind of causal nexus that explains reality. Heidegger’s rejection of divine freedom or will and abandonment of Being to a kind of fate—in contrast to a dramatic covenant relation between God and the world—fatally shatters any hope that Heidegger has of subsuming the Christian form within an ontology of event. The Christian form proves undigestible once that form is contemplated in its integrity.

B. Apophatic Pedagogy to Iconic Apophaticism

If it is the case that Balthasar rejects Vattimo’s advocacy of a Heideggerian Christianity, it is also the case that Balthasar rejects Vattimo’s disposal of the Old Covenant. For Balthasar, Scripture consists not so much of a series of myths to be “interpreted” under the gaze of a philosophical apophaticism that reduces or empties scriptural content, but rather as a kind of sacramental form that must be received and contemplated in its totality. Balthasar’s formal hermeneutic model comes from the realm of aesthetics, where to manipulate or dissect a spiritual work prior to contemplation renders comprehension impossible. Macbeth without the first two acts is no longer Macbeth.

Of course, this formal hermeneutical principle does not inform us as to how the Old Covenant provides revelation.⁸² At least one important way this is so, on Balthasar’s reading, has to do with its apophatic character. Here, Vattimo and Balthasar find some agreement. If the Old Covenant is to be brought back into Christian theology, it cannot be in a purely literal sense; yet the “spiritual sense” of Balthasar will be a Christological contextualization found in the New Testament itself, and thus contestable by it. In addition, Balthasar finds much to be grateful for in the Old Covenant as it de-mythologizes ancient notions of time,⁸³ inscribes the importance of new events of divine and human freedom,⁸⁴ and critiques various cultural notions of justice to replace them with a depiction of justice as filled out by personal love and special care for the poor.⁸⁵ Moreover, for Balthasar the Old Covenant provides an apophatic pedagogy that both facilitates the development of secularism and at the same time chastens it. It facilitates secularism by de-divinizing both the cosmos and humanity through the disclosure of the one God who is Lord of the cosmos, free Creator, and also redeemer of humanity.⁸⁶ The Old Covenant also chastens this same secularism because it provides a constant reminder that the human, regardless of rank or status, is not God. Balthasar believes that this negative quality is not only characteristic of the Old Covenant, but that it helps prepare the way to the incarnation of God’s true image by consistently negating false images. The Old Testament trains us in “idolatry critique.” Nor is this Old Covenant apophaticism passé

for Balthasar. Rather, it serves a critical balance, especially in the modern anthropocentric period, to the New Covenant proclamation that human beings can become partakers of the divine nature by grace.

While the Old Covenant facilitates one kind of secularism, that is, the emptying of the universe's divinity, the New Covenant, if partially interpreted, threatens to support a vision of humanity as divine in its essence. As wonderful as the modern period could be in terms of scientific and artistic accomplishment, and in the general extension of political rights, its intellectual drift, he argues, was a Promethean substitution or subordination of divine glory to human glory. It is this side of modernity and secularism, including its twentieth century disasters often spurred on through grand utopian schemes, that Balthasar brings to light and that Vattimo would seem to consider relatively unimportant. It is the transcendent and Trinitarian God of Jesus Christ, who unites Old and New Covenant, divine transcendence and immanence, that keeps humanity from conceiving itself the equal of God, while nevertheless gaining the dignity of the divine image. For Balthasar, all of this, that is, divine transcendence and immanence, judgment and mercy, are to be maintained simultaneously. We will see this more clearly in the following section, but it is important to note that in contrast to Vattimo, Balthasar refuses to reduce religious language to the isomorphism characteristic, and perhaps necessary, to the natural scientist, but far too simplistic to describe the polymorphic revelations of biblical glory.

For Balthasar, the Old Covenant prepares a "table of categories"⁸⁷ that makes the form of Christ a legible object for contemplation both negatively and positively. These categories are taken up and given their proper interpretive key (not to say single interpretation) through the Christological dénouement that is the Triduum. Christ, for Balthasar, is the iconic measure of truth, goodness, and beauty, but precisely as such is a measure who calls into question the "world's" categories and vision. Philosophical and cultural categories must always suffer re-vision under the humiliation of a kenotic, crucified and exalted Messiah. The best guarantee that Christians will not abandon this responsibility for cultural and self-critique is not the proclamation of the age of Spirit and the baptism of cultural consensus, but the ongoing contemplation and action, mercy and work for justice that follows the descent of the Icon into the darkness, and trusts in the ineffable golden background that is the blinding presence of the Father's love. Balthasar, however, does not stop his reflection at this point. Rather, he moves daringly from this descent into the inner life of the Trinity.

III. Trinity and Difference

Like Vattimo, Balthasar considers the Trinity Christianity's key symbol for organizing meaning. Moreover, Balthasar shares Vattimo's desire to stress the importance of the world and the historicity and contingency of human exist-

ence, and the central, normative importance of love. Balthasar, however, explicitly rejects Joachim's Trinitarian progressivism, especially but not exclusively in its modern variations. His rejection derives from the view that such a Trinitarian theology supports modern Prometheanism and utopian movements that have proven catastrophic for the twentieth century. Trinitarian theologies that leave divine transcendence behind end up, he thinks, declaring some social or political organization absolute.⁸⁸ Such political organizations, however, lack the "No" to idolatry found in the Old Testament and the burr of self-criticism one might contemplate in the Christ of the gospels. Balthasar contends that this theological development is decidedly errant, not least because it revives a form of Marcionism that would detach and even oppose Old Covenant and New Covenant revelation, Jews and Christians.⁸⁹

One general point that Vattimo makes, however, would find appreciation from Balthasar. Vattimo resists any notion that the divine-world relation should be conceived in terms of simple divine remoteness or "wholly otherness." Although Balthasar does think that the transcendence of the Old Covenant God empties the cosmos of divinity, he does not think that either Jewish or Christian theology can stop with a mere negation of pantheism and cosmocentrism. If God reveals himself as wholly other through theophanic disclosure,⁹⁰ this same God reveals his care and mercy within Israel's covenant relation. Indeed, for Balthasar, neither divine mercy nor divine intimacy are foreign to Old Covenant revelation, whether within Israel's psalms, the Covenant law, the divine attributes or virtues that are incarnated within Israel's community and worship, or the divine Word spoken and embodied by the servant and the prophets.⁹¹ God is not restricted to the heavens or constricted by the cosmos, but freely imparts divine life to his people in acts of judgment and mercy.

Thus "wholly other" does not suffice to describe Israel's God. Instead, Balthasar suggests Nicholas of Cusa's "non-other" as a necessary supplement.⁹² The concrete results of analogous religious language become clear when Balthasar observes that while the divine is "other" to us, we cannot be "other" to God since that might designate some limitation on divine Being. The language of otherness is asymmetrical. God is other as non-other, as "more intimate to me than I am to myself" in the famous phrase of Augustine. Balthasar contends that the finite world finds its place in God, though even this paradoxical view requires a Trinitarian broadening for it not to imply a stable placement of the world as a thing within a larger Being. What is necessary, Balthasar argues, is a ground for freedom that is freedom itself, and a ground for otherness that discloses the Other in the Non-Other. In other words, Balthasar argues for a theology that grounds the validity of a world that is free and not God, but whose freedom and difference is grounded in the nature of the divine itself. What this means for the secular is that there is no pure secularity, either in the sense that culture is identical to divinity or in the sense that culture is devoid of relation to the divine or grace.

Instead, culture finds the ground of its Being as other than God and the ground of its freedom vis-à-vis the divine within the divine life itself. But then it is also within this life that culture finds its measure and norm.

It is crucial not to leap too quickly to Trinitarian theology here, for to do so would threaten a kind of formalistic theology of Trinitarian relations unrelated to Christ's mission in history. Balthasar does not wish to treat the Trinity as a symbolic logic of difference-and-otherness-reconciled in any abstract sense. Instead, he wants to work up into Trinitarian relations from the dramatic-narrative of Israel and Christ. Christ's mission—and not a kind of three part logic—provides the only justification for Trinitarian theology, and Christ's mission does not end in an identity between humanity and God.⁹³ In addition, the pattern of Christ's mission must always inform Trinitarian "speculation," while Trinitarian speculation can deepen reflection on Christ's mission and the God-world relation. In Balthasar's hands, this reflection takes account of Heidegger's and Vattimo's concern for historicity, for the possibility of new events of revelation, and for a genuine pluralism that Vattimo's system cannot countenance. After all, if secularism for Vattimo is the realization of divine self-development, then any non-secular worldview is systematically consigned to falsehood and naïveté.

Balthasar's Trinitarian theology, though in a sense speculative, remains grounded in the economy of God's free self-revelation. This economy moves from human being as image of God to the disclosure of God's own Image in Christ. What the *imago* suggests to Balthasar is that the divine Image, from the beginning, holds "sway" over one's own image, even when the extremes of human freedom go their way. The image is the *imago trinitatis*, an image that evokes movement, giving, and self-transcendence in surrender. The dynamism inherent to Balthasar's vision of the Trinity determines as well his vision of presence. Presence is not the "present-to-hand" of Heidegger's useful instruments and calculative thinking. For Balthasar, presence is the "ever-greater" "coming towards us" which human beings cannot master.⁹⁴ The comparative "ever-greater" is characteristic of Balthasar's resistance to a conceptualization of God as superlative object (the highest good), a concept which can be construed as a being;⁹⁵ in addition, the genitive in "coming towards us" stresses energy and activity and does not point to a being which comes towards us. The image that human beings are, then, speaks both to their dignity and, for Balthasar, to the primacy of God's time over human time. Presence is not "the present," but 'presencing' that can make new things happen, call new beings out of nothing, and evoke new Christologically grounded missions in history. Presence is always uncontrollable surplus.

Balthasar roots this dynamic view of presence centrally within the mission of Christ, and from this mission in the inner Trinitarian processions themselves. Following Thomas and Bonaventure, he views the processions within the Trinity as "cause and ground of all creaturely processions."⁹⁶ The entire emphasis here will be on the free generosity and prodigality of divine self-

giving both within the Trinity and *ad extra* or in the world. Following Bonaventure, Balthasar envisions the Father who gives the Son both his being and the being of creatures so that the Son forms a center or microcosm of both. Especially in Bonaventure, the Spirit takes form as gift, as "God's communicability on the basis of his generosity."⁹⁷ For both Thomas and Bonaventure, creation is a free act of will rooted in the eternal procession of the Son by nature.

Although for Balthasar creation is an act of divine freedom, and not an act of divine necessity as it is in Hegelian discourse, Balthasar refuses to eschew language of process,⁹⁸ *eros*, or *kenosis* for the inner Trinitarian life and for creation. Instead, Christ's disclosure of divine superabundance re-signifies or specifies all three terms. Thus process means not a development from divine need to divine self-fulfillment, that is, not *eros* in the Platonic-Hegelian sense⁹⁹—but the "superabundant vitality of infinite life itself,"¹⁰⁰ the Son as a fulfillment that exceeds even the expectations of the Father.¹⁰¹ It follows that *eros* will not imply that God creates from need; yet for Balthasar creation does not exclude divine desire. Insofar as Christ forms the center, measure, and goal of the divine economy, he argues, God has always desired to create and give freedom to creatures.¹⁰² Thus Balthasar re-signifies "*eros*" through "*agape*." Desire springs from generosity and fullness rather than lack. *Agape* similarly specifies the meaning of *kenosis*. Balthasar never allows *kenosis* a literalist or univocist interpretation found in Hegel, Altizer, and Vattimo. Instead, *kenosis* is the total self-giving that characterizes the Father's procession of the Son without, however, any suggestion of divine self-development. This type of *kenosis* or "super-death" finds analogy in the "good death" of human self-giving, self-forgetfulness, and laying down of one's life that Jesus not only espouses but does.¹⁰³ We should notice here that analogy does not move towards identity understood as strict equivalence. Human behavior toward other human beings is similar to, but infinitely different from the Father's action toward the Son. Balthasar's view of *kenosis* points away from identity metaphysics and towards the opening up of difference within the divine life itself.

Everything we have said about Balthasar's Trinitarian theology points to self-transcendence as creative self-surrender, to action and to surprise. Balthasar finds in the world a kind of play that is worthy of delight even in the midst of terrible tragedy. It is this "play," that is, the world's becoming and continual newness that Balthasar roots in the continual procession of the Son from the Father, what he would have us think of as a kind of coming to be of a ground for earthly becoming, an eternal "happening" reflected in finite events.¹⁰⁴ Balthasar thus seeks to overturn the "Parmenidean" contrast between Being and becoming and to give becoming itself a ground in the self-transcending divine life. Metaphysically speaking, history is a positive intention of the divine life, grounded in the divine nature as mutual eventful love, and not an unfortunate fall from a pristine state. This does not mean that history is incapable of going horribly wrong. The freedom permitted human

beings and culture is a freedom to reject the divine life upon which their very being is predicated. Grace for Balthasar is not coercion, but the persuasion of the beautiful offered to freedom. Indeed, it is at least in part the rejection of divine love that makes the Christian narrative a dramatic narrative in which Christians engage the world in an almost unlimited number of ways with the fullness of reconciliation as an always asymptotic goal.

In another way, too, difference and plurality can be grounded in the Trinitarian relations opened to view through the "pattern of redemption"¹⁰⁵—in Edward Oakes' felicitous phrase—disclosed in Christ. For Balthasar, the inner-worldly "real distinction" between the individual, incommunicable nature of any thing and the limited participation of all things in Being also finds its ground in the unity-in-difference of the Trinitarian Persons.¹⁰⁶ The Father remains Father even as the Father gives his being to the Son. The picture that emerges of the divine life is one of positive paradox, of unity and relation, peace and movement, event and form (super-form), self-expression and self-surrender and a continuous vitality that always lets the other be as other.¹⁰⁷ What's more, if the real distinction finds its ground in the Triune life, so does the world's unlikeness to God. It is the "divine kindness" that not only gives Being, but also form as other-than-God.¹⁰⁸ If human beings only find fulfillment in self-surrender for their neighbor, this mode of fulfillment reflects the Triune relations as their identity is determined in the relations of self-surrender and expression. Space, time, creativity each find their roots in the self-surrender, self-transcendence, and gift of the Trinitarian relations, in the "area" opened up through begetting, the "interval" of response, the "letting-be" of otherness.

All of this is highly suggestive, for if I read Balthasar correctly, his theological reflections imply that there is no fixed thing we can name 'the secular.' The secular describes not a reified entity, but a relationship the world has with God, that is, the world as revealed in its creatureliness and gratuitousness through this relationship. In contrast to both Hegel and Vattimo, Balthasar would posit a distinction between salvation and secular history. For if there is no difference, as Vattimo says,¹⁰⁹ then the world in fact has no autonomy vis-à-vis the divine; instead, cultural movements will be tightly tied to revelation, thus distorting both salvation and secular history to make each fit a single vision of the other.¹¹⁰ Once again, monologue will trump dialogue. For Balthasar, elements of existence in the world must be weighed against the revelation of salvation history, with its summit in Christ, while salvation history itself receives illumination from this dialogue. No systematic view of this diversity is possible or plausible; rather, contemplation of the "signs of the times *in light of the gospel*" is an ongoing endeavor that sees the world as destined for self-surrender, self-transcendence, and consummation in all its genuine goods and in ever new ways. This relationship, for Balthasar, is distorted when human beings refuse transcendence or despise their gratuitous nature in favor of a Promethean utopianism, or when Christians

refuse genuine engagement with the world. Otherness, we might emphasize, is always for Balthasar "otherness-in-relation." Whether it chooses to acknowledge its master or not, the secular always lives within and in relation to its Christological norm; indeed, that norm grounds its very being as secular. Thus for Balthasar, contemplation and the sacramental life are authentic insofar as they live attentively to the needs of this world; in his terms, theological aesthetics leads into theological dramatics. There is no leaving behind the world for God or God for the world. Indeed, the Christian exists as the "shepherd of Being," as the one who gives thanks for the world in all its splendor, variety, and dynamism, who would oppose those who with violence reduce it to a monotony of color and tone, or would claim the suffering of others is written in the stars.

Conclusion

The Balthasarian critique I have offered here of Gianni Vattimo's thought is designed to shed light on aspects of his work that are highly problematic from a philosophical and theological perspective. I have argued that Vattimo's view of revelation, while appearing to extol contemplation and surprise, can countenance little that is not already confined within a philosophy that controls and eliminates revelatory content. Hegelian philosophy in particular dominates Vattimo's thought, even where he thinks he has properly adjusted it. In the end, this means that event is opposed to form, Spirit to incarnation and Church, contemplation to action, even Old Covenant to New, transcendent God to the world. In each case, one pole must triumph over the other so that theological content, existential style, and the complexity and tension of living in the world as a religious person get narrowed. System eviscerates experience.

At each level of his theological oeuvre, Balthasar takes a stand for Christian pluralism. His aesthetic starting point that refuses the either-or between event and form; his theological dramatics that holds Christians responsible not merely for a contemplative beholding of revelation and the world, but also for acting on the world's behalf; his philosophical critique of Heidegger when Heidegger would prematurely proscribe avenues of contemplation and wonder; his refusal to reduce religious language to a univocal calculus of the divine; and his grounding of otherness, newness, freedom and becoming in the self-transcending love of Trinitarian relation all reflect his basic view that a genuine Christian spirit is one that seeks to embrace the world in God, without making the world into its God.

NOTES

- 1 Three recent texts on these issues come to mind, all of which offer a complex treatment of the development and definition of secularism. See Marcel Gauchet's *The Disenchantment of*

the World: A Political History of Religion, trans. By Oscar Burge (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1997); Talal Asad, *Formations of the Secular: Christianity, Islam, Modernity* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2003); Tomoko Masuzawa, *The Invention of World Religions: Or, How European Universalism Was Preserved in the Language of Pluralism* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2005). Asad and Masuzawa tend toward complexifying and problematizing "the secular" while Gauchet and Vattimo would offer a grand narrative view. Of course complexity and narrative are not necessarily opposed.

- 2 Both defenders and detractors of Hegel can agree that he engages in ontotheology. For a defender's view, see Peter Hodgson's introduction in G. W. F. Hegel: *Theologian of the Spirit* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1997), p. 7. Hodgson would argue that any worthwhile theology is an ontotheology, and does not admit the more pernicious aspects of the label into his discussion.
- 3 The English translation of Balthasar's *Theological Aesthetics* is in seven volumes. References here will be abbreviated here as GL followed by the volume and then the page number. References to his *Theological Dramatics* will be abbreviated as TD followed volume and then the page. Hans Urs von Balthasar, *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics, Vol. 1, Seeing the Form*, trans. by Erasmo Leiva-Merikakis, ed. by Joseph Fessio, S. J., and John Riches (San Francisco and New York: Ignatius Press and Crossroad, 1982); *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics, Vol. 2, Studies in Theological Style: Clerical Styles*, trans. by Andrew Louth, Francis McDonagh and Brian McNeil, C. R. V., ed. by J. Riches (San Francisco and New York: Ignatius Press and Crossroad, 1984); *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics, Vol. 3, Studies in Theological Style: Lay Styles*, trans. by Andrew Louth, John Saward, Martin Simon and Rowan Williams, ed. by J. Riches (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1986); *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics, Vol. 4, The Realm of Metaphysics in Antiquity*, trans. by Andrew Louth, Brian McNeil, C. R. V., John Saward, Rowan Williams and Oliver Davies, ed. by J. Riches (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1989); *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics, Vol. 5, The Realm of Metaphysics in the Modern Age*, trans. by Oliver Davies, Andrew Louth, John Saward and Martin Simon, ed. by J. Riches and B. McNeil (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1991); *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics, Vol. 6, Theology: The Old Covenant*, trans. by Erasmo Leiva-Merikakis and Brian McNeil, C. R. V., ed. by J. Riches (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1991); *The Glory of the Lord: A Theological Aesthetics, Vol. 7, Theology: The New Covenant*, trans. by Brian McNeil, C. R. V., ed. by J. Riches (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1989). *Theo-Drama* is the second part of von Balthasar's trilogy. It consists in English of five volumes: *Theo-Drama: Theological Dramatic Theory, Vol. 1: Prolegomena*, trans. by Graham Harrison (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1988); *Theo-Drama: Theological Dramatic Theory, Vol. 2: Dramatis Personae: Man in God*, trans. by Graham Harrison (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1990); *Theo-Drama: Theological Dramatic Theory, Vol. 3: The Dramatis Personae: The Person in Christ*, trans. by Graham Harrison (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1992); *Theo-Drama: Theological Dramatic Theory, Vol. 4: The Action*, trans. by Graham Harrison (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1994); *Theo-Drama: Theological Dramatic Theory, Vol. 5: The Last Act*, trans. by Graham Harrison (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1998).
- 4 For a very different view of Nietzsche's cultural effects, see Jonathan Glover, *Humanity: A Moral History of the Twentieth Century* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2001).
- 5 Heidegger addresses these themes in a variety of places. In *Introduction to Metaphysics*, he is concerned to reject a modern and contemporary philosophical tendency to read Platonic and Aristotelian thought as the proper ground for and perfection of earlier Greek thinking on Being. This means for Heidegger that *physis* must be related to *logos* in such a way that *logos* does not become an atemporal reality or series of blueprints of which beings in time are only copies. Idea then becomes the "sole and decisive interpretation of being" (p. 182). This represents a "falling off" (*Ibid.*). The move of *physis* into Latin (both Rome and Christian middle ages) and from that translation into modern philosophy, for Heidegger, represents a movement of decline, "deformation" and "decay," from *physis* as emergent energy or "blossoming-forth" to *natura*, a movement by which "the actual philosophical force of the Greek word is destroyed" (p. 13). Modern and contemporary philosophy and science, he thinks, consider Being in terms of beings and thinking in terms not of contemplation or wonder or questioning, but in terms of calculation and clever quantification. Emergence and epiphany, surprise, and becoming all become devalued (see esp. pp. 46–49).

and p. 63). A movement to interpret *physis* as *ousia*/substance is equally detrimental to Heidegger's view. See Martin Heidegger, *Contributions to Philosophy: from enowning*, translated by Parvis Emad and Kenneth Maly (Bloomington, IN: Indiana University Press, 1999), p. 156 #113. The movement into Latin is not incidental to this decline for Heidegger. He views Greek and German as properly philosophical languages; Latin is not, and presumably the same can be said for English and Russian. Heidegger, then, sees himself as engaged in a "vocation" to bring Western civilization back to its primordial energies in the early "pre-Socratic" Greeks by connecting the Greek language of Being with German and dispensing with whatever intervened—a destruction for a re-construction. *Physis* designates a kind of power of emergence and logos the limitation or "gathering" of that power to a particular *essent*.

- 6 "From the Nietzschean-Heideggerian perspective in which I place myself, nihilism is the loss of credence in an objective truth in favor of a perspective that conceives of truth as an effect of power in the manifold senses of this expression: as a scientific experiment that realizes the *principium reddendae rationis*, its foundation the active will of the subjects who set up the experiment and of those who within a historical paradigm, which is not necessarily arbitrary, adhere to its validity; as an ideology that members of a social class hold to be true; and as a lie invented by monks to justify power and social discipline" Gianni Vattimo, *After Christianity*, trans. by Luca D'Isanto (New York, NY: Columbia University Press, 2002), p. 105.
- 7 "In the first place, one will at the very least have to speak of Being not in terms of an object or state of affairs, but in terms of 'event,' as Heidegger says" Gianni Vattimo, *Beyond Interpretation*, trans. by David Webb (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1997), pp. 11–12; "it is above all because of the experience of postmodern pluralism that we can think of Being only as event, and of truth not as a reflection of reality's eternal structure but rather as a historical message that must be heard and to which we are called to respond." Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 6. For Heidegger, "event" or "enowning," each different translations of the German "*ereignis*," does not indicate merely a momentary happening or occurrence, but rather a change in Being that might take centuries to gestate and come to birth. For explanation of the translation, see Martin Heidegger, *Contributions to Philosophy: from enowning*, translator's foreword, pp. xix–xxii. Such is the death of God and the Nietzschean announcement of nihilism. Culture is "enowned" or under the "sway" of this emergence. The German title is *Beiträge zur Philosophie (Vom Ereignis)*, ed. by Wilhelm von Herrmann (Frankfurt am Main: Vittorio Klostermann, 1989). The book was completed in 1937.
- 8 Vattimo starkly opposes the God of the Bible to the God of medieval metaphysics. Nietzsche, according to him, does faith a favor by eliminating the latter to make room for the former. Commenting on Nietzsche's "God is Dead" parable, he writes that the faithful have discovered that God himself is a superfluous lie. However, in light of our postmodern experience, this means: since God can no longer be upheld as an ultimate foundation, as the absolute metaphysical structure of the real, it is possible, once again, to believe in God. True, it is not the God of metaphysics or of medieval scholasticism. But that is not the God of the Bible, of the Book that was dissolved and dismissed by modern rationalist and absolutist metaphysics" See Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 6. "Even more than in Dostoyevsky, though, faithfulness to the gospel should be sought in Nietzsche, and especially in his announcement of the death of God. The God who has been killed by his followers is only—and rightly—the moral God . . ." (*Ibid.*, p. 104). Moreover, such claims are not merely the musings of prominent philosophers, but to Vattimo at least help describe the reality of our present cultural experience: "I argue . . . that the Nietzschean announcement of the death of God and the Heideggerian announcement . . . of the end of metaphysics can provide the general framework for characterizing late-modern experience" (*Ibid.*, p. 20). Of course he would need to square this assessment of late-modern experience with his view that an attraction to traditional religious forms has also arisen and gained momentum of late.
- 9 Not only Heidegger's ontology, but also his theological gestures condition Vattimo's thought. In his tribute to the German Catholic theologian, Max Scheler, Heidegger approves of Scheler's "enormous boldness" in seeing the "idea of the weak God, one who cannot be God without man, so that man himself is thought of as 'God's co-worker'." All

this was far removed from a smug theism or a vague pantheism. Scheler's scheme moved toward a philosophical anthropology, an attempt to work out the special position of man. See Martin Heidegger, *The Metaphysical Foundations of Logic*, trans. by Michael Heim (Bloomington, IN: Indiana University Press, 1992), p. 51. Heidegger sees Scheler's catholicism in lower-case universalistic terms rather than in ecclesial terms (*Ibid.*). In a later, 1957 essay, Heidegger will suggest that in fact "god-less thinking may be more open to Him [the divine God] than onto-theo-logic would like to admit." See Martin Heidegger, "The Onto-theo-logical Constitution of Metaphysics", in *Identity and Difference*, trans. by Joan Stambaugh (New York, NY: Harper and Row, 1969), p. 72. The contrast here is between the god of philosophy, the *causa sui*, and the "divine God." In his *Introduction to Metaphysics*, a text of his 1935 lectures, Christianity is evaluated negatively in relation to philosophical questioning, certainly as to its Latin medieval tradition, but also in terms of its biblical and *pistic* roots. See *Introduction to Metaphysics*, pp. 6–7. If the vocation of philosophy is questioning and opening paths for questions, then biblical faith in the Creator closes off questioning by answering the primordial philosophical question, "Why is there something rather than nothing?" with a Being.

- 10 Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 6. Of course claims to radical historicity are themselves absolute claims.
- 11 Vattimo, *Beyond Interpretation*, p. 10; cf. p. 11.
- 12 Luca D'Isanto, "Gianni Vattimo's Hermeneutics and the Trace of Divinity," *Modern Theology*, Vol. 10 no. 4 (October 1994), p. 362. See also Vattimo, *Beyond Interpretation*, p. 12: "If our hypothesis stands, hermeneutics is legitimated as a narrative of modernity, that is, of its own provenance; and moreover it is also, indeed above all, a narrative of the meaning of Being."
- 13 See Vattimo, *Beyond Interpretation*, pp. 1–14.
- 14 *Ibid.*, p. 13. Vattimo justifies this interpretation of Heidegger as an extension of Heidegger's interpretation of the ontological difference. The nihilistic vocation of hermeneutics indicates that the ontological difference arises precisely in the giving of Being as "suspension and withdrawal" as opposed to any kind of presence, even the presence of nothing. Vattimo's reading of the ontological difference suggests that certitude must be withheld from all social and institutional forms that would link themselves to a static, graspable and atemporal structure so as to assume an authority that should be considered philosophically suspect.
- 15 See Vattimo, *Beyond Interpretation*, p. 13. Vattimo rejects what he calls an "apophasic theology" that he associates with "right-wing Heideggerians" for the nihilistic vocation of Being that he advocates. He supports this interpretation of Heidegger, even beyond Heidegger's own intentions, because he thinks that it better preserves the ontological difference central to Heidegger's thought (*Ibid.*). Vattimo claims that Heidegger and Nietzsche in some sense "remain captive to Greek objectivism and refuse to develop fully the implications of Christianity's antimetaphysical revolution. These cannot be fully developed without recourse to charity" (Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 111).
- 16 Nihilism, in Heidegger's interpretation of Nietzsche, indicates not a particular viewpoint, but rather is an "event of long duration in which the truth of being as a whole is essentially transformed and driven toward an end that such truth has determined" (*Nietzsche, Vol. IV: Nihilism*, translated by Joan Stambaugh, David Farrell Krell, Frank A. Capuzzi (San Francisco, CA: HarperSanFrancisco, 1982), pp. 4–5). Heidegger reads Nietzsche to proclaim a new age in which the death of God heralds the end of the transcendent as a place from which values and meaning emerge: "Nihilism is that historical process whereby the dominance of the 'transcendent' becomes null and void, so that all being loses its worth and meaning. Nihilism is the history of the being itself, through which the death of the Christian God comes slowly but inexorably to light" (*Ibid.*, p. 4).
- 17 Gianni Vattimo, *Belief*, trans. by David Webb, (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1999), p. 32.
- 18 *Ibid.*, p. 44. The full passage is of some interest: "We are able to recognize that the history of Being has a 'reductive,' nihilistic meaning, a tendency to assert the truth of Being by reducing the compelling nature of the entities (whether they be political authority, the threatening and bizarre God of natural religion, or the peremptory finality of the modern subject understood as the guarantor of truth), only because we have been educated by the Christian tradition to think of God not as a master but as a friend, to proclaim that essential

things are revealed not to the wise but to the little ones, to believe that whoever does not lose his soul will not save it, and so on."

- 19 In *After Christianity* (p. 17), Vattimo also dismisses positivist and historicist arguments against religious faith as either unscientific or as intellectually passé. For Vattimo, as he notes elsewhere, the line between reason and faith can no longer be drawn thickly in a post-metaphysical landscape (Vattimo, *Belief*, pp. 86–87).
- 20 On the connection between Vattimo's use of Joachim and the ontological weakening thesis, see *After Christianity*, p. 44; for the relation between a spiritual sense reading of scripture and secularism, see *After Christianity*, pp. 45 and 47. Vattimo writes, "My argument is that our epoch must be treated as the age of the spiritual interpretation of the biblical message" (p. 47). Also: "This is the sense in which I employ the term secularization: it is an interpretive application of the biblical message that situates it beyond the strictly sacramental, sacral, or ecclesiastical realm. Whoever argues that this gesture betrays the biblical message obviously defends the literal interpretation of Christian doctrine, which, therefore, can be legitimately opposed by the idea of secularization as 'spiritual' interpretation" (p. 45).
- 21 Vattimo, *Belief*, p. 50; see also Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 36: "To understand modernity as secularization, namely as the inner and 'logical' development of the Judaeo-Christian revelation, and to grasp the dissolution of metaphysics as the manifestation of Being as event, as its philosophical outcome, means to read the signs of the times, in the spirit of Joachim of Fiore and of his spiritual disciples such as Novalis, Schelling, and Schleiermacher." Cf. *Belief*, p. 52 and *After Christianity*, p. 67.
- 22 Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 27.
- 23 See Vattimo, *Belief*, pp. 59–60 which opposes Jesus to "ecclesiastical authoritarianism which fixes the meaning of revelation once and for all in the form of irrational myths, to which we are expected to adhere in the name of God's absolute transcendence, which is both metaphysical and violent." See also, Vattimo, *After Christianity*, pp. 45–47 and 49.
- 24 See especially, Vattimo, *Belief*, pp. 71–74. It is interesting to observe that Vattimo's option for event as nihilistic turns over the Augustinian view that the world is essentially good in all its essences, and that the annihilation of essence, of God's good creation, is evil.
- 25 See Vattimo, *Belief*, pp. 39 and 49 and Vattimo, *After Christianity*, where Vattimo writes, "Every attempt to read revelation as a teaching on the nature and attributes of God falls into the same error of representational thought—the sin of objectifying metaphysics—against which we are called to recover the hearing of Being" (p. 133). It is worth mentioning here that salvation, for Vattimo, comes in the form of interpretation, that is, knowledge more nearly than active love or biblical faith, even if he wants to stress a formal notion of love as the sole Christian ethic. See Vattimo, *Belief*, p. 60.
- 26 See especially, Vattimo, *After Christianity*, pp. 44–45, 46–47 and 49.
- 27 *Ibid.*, p. 27.
- 28 *Ibid.*, 37. See also, *Belief*, where Vattimo associates Catholic regression to metaphysics and literalism with Old Testament faith and laments the "predominance of Judaic religiosity in the return of religion into contemporary thought (no anti-semitic intention whatsoever)" (p. 84).
- 29 Vattimo, *Belief*, p. 84. See *Ibid.*, p. 83 for the comment on Old Testament faith.
- 30 Gotthold E. Lessing, "The Education of the Human Race," in *Lessing's Theological Writings*, trans. by Henry Chadwick (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1957). For Lessing in this essay the Old Testament is a helpful primer that must go away once its rational truths have been gleaned lest one become religiously remedial. For Hegel, in *Lectures on the Philosophy of Religion*, Judaism depicts a kind of alienation between God and the world that is at once helpful in spiritualizing the relation between the divine and human and transcending naturalism, but is also definitively past as Spirit has moved on toward its reconciliation with the world. See G. W. F. Hegel, *Lectures on the Philosophy of Religion*, trans. by Peter C. Hodgson, (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1988) [abbreviated here as *LPR*], pp. 328–375.
- 31 Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 31.
- 32 *Ibid.*
- 33 Vattimo, *Beyond Interpretation*, p. 14.

- 34 Alexander Pope, *Essay on Man*, X.294, although I am aware that Pope may suffer an injustice in the comparison. I am also aware that this may not represent Vattimo's actual politics. I am arguing only that this is the direction in which his theory heads.
- 35 See Vattimo, *After Christianity*, pp. 33–35. See p. 34 for Vattimo's hesitation regarding the tone of Novalis. For Novalis, see, pp. 69, 74–75, and 80–82.
- 36 Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 42.
- 37 *Ibid.*, pp. 9 and 53–56.
- 38 The language of "sway" and "moira" is prominent in Heidegger's *Contributions to Philosophy: from enowning* and in his essay on Parmenides. For "sway" see the entire section entitled "The Essential Sway of Truth," in *Contributions to Philosophy*, pp. 229–256 and also pp. 271–274. For "moira" see Martin Heidegger, *Early Greek Thinking: The Dawn of Western Philosophy*, trans. by David Farrell Krell (New York, NY: Harper and Row, 1984), pp. 79–102. On destiny, see also "The Ontological Constitution of Metaphysics" in Heidegger, *Identity and Difference*, p. 51.
- 39 See, for instance, Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 91.
- 40 See especially Cyril O'Regan's analysis in *The Heterodox Hegel* (New York, NY: State University of New York Press, 1994). On Hegel's opposition to apophaticism, and on the Romantic intuitionists that are his targets, see pp. 31–44. It should be pointed out that an emphasis on negation does not *ipso facto* elude the Hegelian magnetic pull. Hegel builds negation into his system via the Son's negation of divine unity. While Vattimo wants to maintain negation as a *modus operandi*, his system reaches a kind of presence in the form of the secular, not unlike Hegel's own work.
- 41 Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 37.
- 42 *Ibid.*
- 43 Thomas Altizer, *The Gospel of Christian Atheism* (Philadelphia, PA: Westminster Press, 1966), p. 25.
- 44 *Ibid.*
- 45 *Ibid.*
- 46 *Ibid.*, p. 27.
- 47 *Ibid.*, p. 52.
- 48 *Ibid.*; cf. p. 62: "The 'atheism' of the radical Christian is in large measure a prophetic reaction to a distant and nonredemptive God who by virtue of his very sovereignty and transcendence stands wholly apart from the forward movement and the historical presence of the Incarnate Word. It is precisely because the radical Christian seeks a total union with the Word made flesh that he must refuse the God who alone is God and give himself to a quest for the God who is Jesus." "Christian scholasticism" mistakenly baptized Aristotelian notions of God as *actus purus* or *causa sui*, and thus moved away from a philosophy that might give genuine expression to the Incarnation (*Ibid.*).
- 49 *Ibid.*, p. 67.
- 50 So Hegel can write, "The divine nature is the same as the human, and it is this unity that is beheld." See G. W. F. Hegel, *Phenomenology of Spirit*, trans. by A. V. Miller (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1977), p. 460 #759. This title will be abbreviated as *PS* followed by the page and paragraph number. For Hegel, the incarnation reconciles substance and Spirit or self-consciousness; God attains to self-consciousness in and through the incarnation, and this is the "simple content of the absolute religion" (*PS*, p. 459 #759). What is interesting is that not only does the system logically require the incarnation for God to come to self-consciousness, but the sending of the Spirit is equally necessary for Spirit must not remain as an individual self. The Notion demands universal expression (*PS*, pp. 461–462 #762). Spirit becomes the "universal self-consciousness of the religious community" (*PS*, p. 462 #763). Yet one still needs a "higher formative development of consciousness" that gets beyond the external connections and the Here and Beyond split of "picture-thinking" (*PS*, pp. 462–463 #764). Hegel wants to transcend the seeming singularity and freedom of particular revelatory events and show their inner logic, their organic connections, and their formal and teleological necessity. According to Hegel, in his 1827 *Lectures on the Philosophy of Religion*, trans. by Peter C. Hodgson, (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1988) [abbreviated here as *LPR*], consciousness develops in essentially three modes after the incarnation, modes that recapitulate earlier oppositions and sublations. The first moment has the Christian Church renounce and turn away from the world. The second moment,

that of Catholicism or Christendom, has the Church dominate the world. Neither of these are, properly speaking, true reconciliations and the second is a kind of anti-reconciliation or negative moment. Withdrawal does not allow the heart to develop outwardly so the spirituality of reconciliation is truncated; the second moment envisions a dominance of the reconciled community over the unreconciled world, but the reconciled community becomes all too worldly and "devoid of spirit" as a result. This, for Hegel, is the "corruption of the Church, the absolute contradiction of the spiritual within itself" (LPR, p. 483). Hegel is referring here to the sacred-clerical, lay-secular division of the world which, he believes, consigns to the laity a role of servitude in the mire of the unholy. This is the "opposite of genuine reconciliation" (*Ibid.*). It is the "ethical realm" (*Sittlichkeit*) that resolves the problem. Here, "the reconciliation of religion with worldliness and actuality comes about and is accomplished" (*Ibid.*, p. 484). This development is not only progressive and necessary, but necessary based upon the definition of God as reconciled otherness, a definition which becomes the formal and final cause of historical and divine development.

- 51 See Gotthold E. Lessing, "The Education of the Human Race," in *Lessing's Theological Writings*, esp. pp. 82–98, esp. pp. 91–98.
- 52 On positivity, see Hegel, LPR, pp. 393–404 and on the closely related category, that is, representation, see, *Ibid.*, pp. 144–152 and for representation in relation to thought, see, pp. 152–189. For Hegel, positivity designates not merely the stories or pictures of revelation, but also more nearly conceptual doctrines such as the divine attributes, the Trinity and the Incarnation. All doctrines must give up their finite, positive, irrational form to be universalized in conceptual form so that they can testify to the spirit. Philosophy is this testimony.
- 53 Lessing, "The Education of the Human Race," p. 97.
- 54 We have previously cited the first chapter of Vattimo's *Beyond Interpretation* in this regard, but the final chapter of the same book points to the same reading.
- 55 It should be noted that appeals to charity or love cannot of themselves elude Hegelian ontotheology. After all, Hegel's *Philosophy of Religion* itself is an attempt to interpret metaphysics in light of the Christian doctrine of the Trinity as a Trinitarian relation of reconciliation or love. See Hegel, LPR, p. 418.
- 56 See Vattimo, *Belief*, p. 83.
- 57 While Joachim's thought is certainly progressivist, for him God's pedagogy in justice supports a movement of the human community towards charity. This would indicate that for Joachim justice and mercy are not simple opposites. For Hegel, divine benevolence and grace on the one hand, and divine justice on the other, are opposed and are simultaneous attributes of God only for representational thought, not for conceptual thought which will resolve the tension in favor of mercy. This is the option that Vattimo takes. See Hegel, LPR, p. 154.
- 58 After discussing Jesus' historical existence, Hegel writes, "These are the principal moments in the appearance of this man, upon the human view of it. But this is only one side, and it is not a religious view" (LPR, p. 463).
- 59 See Balthasar, *GL1*, pp. 18–19.
- 60 Balthasar, *GL5*, p. 449.
- 61 Balthasar, *GL5*, p. 432, quoting Heidegger's *Einführung in die Metaphysik* (*Introduction to Metaphysics*), p. 48. Balthasar shows that he shares Heidegger's concerns in many places. Yet even here, Heidegger is not necessarily the most profound of interpreters of the modern techno craze. The French Catholic poet, Charles Péguy, saw the dangers before Heidegger, but did not fall prey to Heidegger's fatalism. See Balthasar's commentary on Péguy in *Glory of the Lord*, vol. 3, pp. 401–517. As Kevin Mongrain points out in a soon to be published article in *Pro Ecclesia*, Péguy is a hugely important figure for Balthasar. See also Hans Urs von Balthasar, *The God Question and Modern Man*, trans. by Hilda Graef (New York, NY: Seabury Press, 1967), pp. 54–57.
- 62 Balthasar's opposition to anthropocentric thought is found in his *Love Alone is Credible*, trans. by D. C. Schindler (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 2004). See especially pp. 31–50, "The Anthropological Reduction." See also *GL5* which prosecutes this movement in modern thought on a much grander scale.
- 63 In Martin Heidegger, *Identity and Difference*, pp. 42–74.
- 64 For Heidegger, modern readings of Parmenides mistake the form of Parmenidean thought by reading poetry or myth as imperfect conceptual logic. Such a reading makes it impos-

- sible to have a genuine dialogue with the early Greeks and helps their experience of Being to become lost. See Heidegger, *Early Greek Thinking*, pp. 79–86 and especially pp. 93–94.
- 65 I take it that Derrida's scathing critique in *Of Spirit: Heidegger and the Question*, trans. by Geoffrey Bennington (Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 1989) is in part a claim that Hegel does return in Heidegger's thought and with a vengeance.
- 66 See Balthasar, *GL2*, pp. 211–260.
- 67 We should note here that Heidegger's reading of the philosophical tradition as beginning with the "garden" of the early Greeks, falling away into the Platonic and Aristotelian tradition, and especially the Roman and Western theological tradition, and then rising again thanks to Germany and its linguistic capabilities is also a simplistic metanarrative. Balthasar contests this reading through volumes 2 through 5 of *Glory of the Lord*. Cyril O'Regan interestingly points out Balthasar's positive assessment of the Latin writing Pindar against Heidegger's devaluation of non-Greek and non-Germanic poetry. On Pindar, see Balthasar, *GL4*, pp. 90–100. See Cyril O'Regan, "Von Balthasar's Valorization and Critique of Heidegger's Genealogy of Modernity," in *Christian Spirituality and the Culture of Modernity* (Grand Rapids, MI: Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 1998), pp. 123–158.
- 68 This seems most obvious in his *Introduction to Metaphysics* cited above, but also in Heidegger's treatments of the early Greek thinkers.
- 69 The quotation marks are present here because Heidegger objects explicitly to the title "pre-Socratic." For him, "pre-Socratic" indicates a modern reading of these thinkers as imperfectly or impurely philosophical, as inchoate philosophers who will be corrected by the more rational Plato and by modern epistemologies or German Idealism. For Heidegger, this mistakes the form of Parmenidean thought by reading poetry or myth as imperfect conceptual logic. Such a reading makes it impossible to have a genuine dialogue with the early Greeks and helps their experience of Being to become lost. See Heidegger, *Early Greek Thinking*, pp. 79–86 and especially pp. 93–94.
- 70 See Heidegger, *Introduction to Metaphysics*, pp. 6–7. For Deleuze, however, Heidegger's view of the truth as aletheia or disclosure will also prematurely close off questioning.
- 71 *Ibid.*
- 72 While this is part of Heidegger's critique of ontotheology generally, his reading of Leibniz in *The Metaphysical Foundations of Logic* makes this point forcefully. For Leibniz, even contingent events are genuinely necessary as they are known already by the divine mind. See p. 49 and his assessment of Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason* in relation to Leibniz's "assimilation of factual experience to truths of reason" (p. 50).
- 73 Cyril O'Regan has amply addressed and adjudicated Balthasar's ambivalent assessment of Heidegger's reading of the Western tradition in his essay "Von Balthasar's Valorization and Critique of Heidegger's Genealogy of Modernity," in *Christian Spirituality and the Culture of Modernity*, pp. 123–158 and so it need not detain us here.
- 74 This is a claim repeated by Phillip Blond in his critical review of Vattimo's *Belief*. Blond also rejects Heidegger's reading of the philosophical tradition as forgetful of the ontological difference or of Being. See Phillip Blond, "The Absolute and the Arbitrary," *Modern Theology* Vol. 18 no. 2 (April 2002), pp. 277–285.
- 75 See John D. Caputo, *Heidegger and Aquinas: An Essay on Overcoming Metaphysics* (New York, NY: Fordham University Press, 1982). Caputo, however, would argue that Thomas, as he is most often read, remains vulnerable to the Heideggerian critique of metaphysics.
- 76 Balthasar cites several passages from later works to show that Heidegger himself recognized Being's need of the world in "ever clearer terms": "Speech needs human speaking", "Human essence is given over to truth, because truth needs man"; Being is the "message which needs us as messengers." He then summarizes a key idea: "If world is to come into being historically, then man as agent of choice and as legislator is indispensable" (*GL5*, p. 447 and 447n.133).
- 77 Balthasar argues, especially in *GL4*, that Homer gave to the West a "canon" of divine-mortal difference that allowed for genuine prayer, grace, theophany, and wonder, all of which philosophy often forecloses as it departs from a personal depiction of God and moves toward a relation of identity between humanity or the world and divinity. See *GL4*, pp. 43–78.
- 78 Balthasar, *GL5*, p. 448. Caputo's argument is relevant here. He argues that Thomists who defend Thomas against Heidegger's charge that Thomas was forgetful of Being and of the

ontological difference between Being and beings miss the sharper point of Heidegger's critique, especially the later Heidegger. Caputo does not think that Thomists have responded to Heidegger's view that Thomas fails to account for the event (*ereignis*) that allows Being to be grasped or appropriated in a particular manner given to a particular historical period. In other words, Thomas has not considered the emergence (*physis*) of a particular configuration of Being as *esse* and *ens* (Caputo, *Heidegger and Aquinas*, pp. 3–6). Balthasar, it seems to me, is turning the tables here. He is giving a historical look at Heidegger, and then offering a theological critique: in his emphasis on the event (*ereignis*) of differing, and his decision to rule out theological discourse, Heidegger ends up losing precisely the transcendent dimension of revelation that allows for genuinely new events and wonder in both Homeric and Christian thought. Of course Balthasar is not arguing as a strict Thomist in any event.

- 79 *Ibid.*, p. 621, 624–625.
- 80 See Jean-Luc Marion, *Being Given: Toward a Phenomenology of Givenness*, trans. by Jeffrey L. Kosky (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2002).
- 81 Balthasar, *GL5*, p. 448.
- 82 For a discussion of Balthasar's Scriptural hermeneutic, see W. T. Dickens, *Hans Urs von Balthasar's Theological Aesthetics: A Model for Post-Critical Biblical Interpretation* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 2003).
- 83 Balthasar, *GL1*, p. 649.
- 84 *Ibid.*, p. 635.
- 85 Balthasar, *GL6*, pp. 170–172.
- 86 On this de-divinization and demythologization performed through Israel's experience of its God, see Balthasar, *TD2*, pp. 175–180.
- 87 *GL1*, p. 647.
- 88 See especially Balthasar, *TD2*, pp. 417–425, but also *TD4*, pp. 440, 446–447, and 457–459 and Balthasar's reading of modern intellectual history in the direction of Titanism or Prometheanism in *GL5*, especially in the "Metaphysics of Spirit," pp. 451–596. Hegel is an especially prominent figure in Balthasar's critique in all three of these areas.
- 89 Balthasar opposes Marcionism in many ways. Modern readings of Joachim, he believes, end up in a kind of neo-Marcionism in that they pit New Covenant revelation against the Old Covenant. Marcionism ends up supporting a modern Promethean anthropocentrism by placing the transcendence of God definitively in the past. The pages already cited in *TD2*, *TD4* address these issues, as does Balthasar's small edited volume of passages from Irenaeus: *The Scandal of the Incarnation: Irenaeus against the Heresies*, trans. by John Saward (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius Press, 1990), pp. 1–11.
- 90 The paradoxical character of theophanic disclosure, for Balthasar, also discloses the inadequacy of a linguistically univocal ascription of attributes to God. See Balthasar, *GL6*, pp. 34 and 53.
- 91 For Balthasar, the Servant becomes the "especial mediator of God's *mishpat* to the whole world" (*GL6*, p. 172); he understands *mishpat* as "justice as the fruit of compassion, as grace" (*Ibid.*).
- 92 Balthasar, *TD2*, p. 193.
- 93 See Balthasar, *TD5*, p. 81 for the link between the procession of the Son from the Father and the Son's mission for the world.
- 94 Balthasar, *TD5*, p. 56.
- 95 *Ibid.*, p. 78.
- 96 *Ibid.*, p. 63.
- 97 *Ibid.*, p. 65.
- 98 *Ibid.*, p. 77.
- 99 *Ibid.*
- 100 *Ibid.*, p. 79.
- 101 *Ibid.*, p. 79, quoting Adrienne von Speyr.
- 102 *Ibid.*, p. 83.
- 103 *Ibid.*, p. 84.
- 104 *Ibid.*, p. 68.
- 105 Edward T. Oakes, *Pattern of Redemption: The Theology of Hans Urs von Balthasar* (New York, NY: Continuum, 1994).

- 106 Balthasar, *TD5*, p. 68.
- 107 See Balthasar, *TD5*, p. 75 where Balthasar uses the language of “letting be” from Heidegger, but for the Trinitarian relations; Love is that which lets the other be as truly other and is grateful for this concrete otherness in unity. On the vitality of the divine life, and its not being a kind of homogeneous block of essence, see *Ibid.*, p. 78.
- 108 Balthasar, *TD5*, p. 76. Balthasar writes that “just as the Divine Persons are themselves only insofar as they go out to the Others (who are always Other), the created essences too are themselves only insofar as they go beyond themselves and indicate their primal ground (whence being in its totality shines forth) and their vocation of self-surrender. They are to surrender themselves for their neighbor (whoever he may be) . . .” (*Ibid.*).
- 109 See Vattimo, *After Christianity*, p. 49: “From our perspective, sacred and secular history are, at least in principle, no longer distinguishable.”
- 110 Balthasar deploys this critique against a number of figures at various levels of intensity; theologians subjected to this criticism include Karl Barth, Karl Rahner, Jürgen Moltmann, and G. W. F. Hegel.